



gang and had met me in Dubai... approached me with a stranger. They offered me a 9-mm pistol with ammunition. Then I saw it, I liked it and had a strong desire to purchase the same. They offered it to me for a sum of Rs 40,000. I paid the said amount in cash at my house and purchased the same. He also handed over 8 rounds of the said pistol.

After the riots were over I thought of informing the police about the weapons... or abandoning it altogether at the same spot, but due to the fear of getting reprimanded from my father and spoiling the prestige and name of my family, I kept the weapons... On March 12, 1993, I heard the news of the bomb blasts while I was busy shooting for the film *Jai Vikrant* in Mumbai. I was quite shocked. During the shooting of *Sanam*... Hanif and Samir had boasted about one fellow by the name of Arjun Memon and were telling me that he was a very dynamic and daring fellow and Customs and police fellows were afraid of him and he was a good friend of them. They

also occasionally used to talk about their friendship with Dawood and Anees. On April 2, I left for Mauritius for the shooting of the film *Aatish*, there I was informed by a casual contact that Hanif and Samir have been arrested by the Bombay Police for their complicity in bomb blast.

On hearing the news, I got frightened as these fellows... may tell my name to the police to involve me in the bomb blast case. I contacted my friend Nulwala on telephone and asked him that something is lying in a black-coloured bag which is kept in my hall... and it should be taken away and destroyed immediately, otherwise I shall be in a great trouble. By this time the news about my possession of the AK-56 rifles had appeared in the press and on coming to know about this my father asked me about the truth of this news but I denied the same.... I decided to return to Bombay in between. My father informed my flight details to the police and I was picked up by the police as soon as I landed in Bombay and confessed the whole thing to them.

six years in jail is too long. He was a victim of the times and he committed a mistake because of his paranoia." Reacting to allegations over Bollywood's lack of objectivity in this case, Bhatt says, "How can we have an objective view when we all know him and are close to him?"

Clearly, the industry is more upset over losing a friend rather than a star. The absence of one star has never seriously impacted the operations of Bollywood. Says Prithish Nandy of Prithish Nandy Communications, which had produced the Dutt-starrer *Shabd*, "People will feel that someone from the family is behind bars. But Sanjay has been cautious and has not signed on too much work. He probably anticipated a judgement like this."

Adds director and Dutt's close friend Anubhav Sinha, "Although it was a fear in everybody's mind, we never totally accepted it till it hit us in the face. We were hoping for the best. But Sanju is a very strong man. He has seen so many highs and lows and I'm sure he will emerge stronger out of this too. It's happened twice before when he has not been on the scene. And people did feel that lacuna. After all, it's not easy to take his space because many heroes have come and gone, but Sanjay has remained the rockstar."

Interestingly enough, Bollywood alone is not rooting for the matinee idol. Information and Broadcasting Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunsi has come out strongly against Dutt's conviction. Terming his offence as "unintentional", he has reportedly stated that the actor has already "suffered long enough in the first instance". And the minister is of the firm belief that the conviction will be a big setback to the film industry.

So is the lovable don destined to spend the next four years in prison? Legal experts differ in their views even as Bollywood stands united. No sooner was the sentence given than Dutt's



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